

Bài tập thực hành 4

Is this the end of the High Street?

Take a walk down any 'High Street', normally places full of shops, and you'll notice signs that all is not well: they will say 'To Let'.

The High Street faces real competition from out-of-town retail parks and the steady growth of supermarkets, both in number and in size. There is also the growing trend for people to shop online, combined with a reduction in many families' finances which has affected customer confidence.

Retailing (the sale of goods from a fixed location) is changing too: shopping is becoming a leisure activity as much as a necessity, along with the rise of home delivery services saving time and journeys. Convenience is a powerful motivator for shoppers' behaviour. Is the traditional High Street dying out?

During the last two years, independent retailers have struggled more than the chain stores. Research suggests over 12,000 independent stores closed in 2009. Economies of scale (it is cheaper to buy stock in bulk, so big shops can charge lower prices) are one part of the issue.

Supermarkets have a stronger control over the supply chain and can manipulate prices more effectively. As a result of the decline in smaller stores, there are now many empty shops in most town centres, some of which have been vacant for some time, and have whitewashed windows. What impact do they have on the overall 'feel' of the town for visitors and residents?

More importantly, how does the loss of a familiar shop which has perhaps served decades of local residents affect people at a time when so many other familiar aspects of daily life are under threat? When a shopping mall is being planned, it is very important to secure the key 'anchor' tenants: the big names that can guarantee customers through the doors. Is the disappearance of these familiar local shops and small department stores like losing a link with the past?

The growth of CCTV cameras, use of private security firms and blurring of public and private land has also been an issue in cities such as Exeter. This can result in young people feeling that they are being victimized and forced out of city centres.

Another feature of many city centres is that they are beginning to look very similar to each other. The New Economics Foundation introduced the term 'clone town' in a report published in 2004. This suggests that many High Streets have few individual characteristics - the same shops can be seen in most towns. This was also followed up by a report in 2010, which identified Cambridge as the most 'cloned' city in the UK: one with very few independent stores in the centre.

Vacant shops are another issue for town centres. These can end up as charity shops, 'pop-up shops (especially around Christmas) or attract vandals and graffiti. Some cities such as

Portsmouth have made an effort to revamp empty store-fronts to improve those areas where they are found. This is important for cities which attract large numbers of tourists, such as Bath, York and Chester.

Services are perhaps more resilient to these changes, particularly those that offer something that is not available online. As one person commented: "You can't have your hair cut online.. well, not yet anyway. This partly explains the growth of coffee shops and nail bars in some town centres, which are going against the general trend.

Finally, out on the edges of our towns, the supermarkets continue to grow - they've got the town centre surrounded. A report published in late 2010 said that around 55p of every £1 that we spend is spent in supermarkets, and there have been a large number of planning applications for further stores.

Read the following passage and answer the questions.

Đọc toàn bộ đoạn văn sau và chọn Yes, No hoặc Not Given cho mỗi statement dưới đây

- Yes - Statement đồng tình với quan điểm của tác giả
- No - Statement trái ngược với quan điểm của tác giả
- NOT GIVEN - Không thể biết được quan điểm của tác giả là gì

Not only are supermarkets getting bigger, there are more of them than ever.	• A. Yes • B. No • C. Not Given
People shop because they have to, but also because it is fun.	• A. Yes • B. No • C. Not Given
The younger generation may feel unwelcome in certain towns.	• A. Yes • B. No • C. Not Given
Although most towns have the same shops, there are many features that make them unique.	• A. Yes • B. No • C. Not Given
Although a large number of stores are closing, the number of shops that offer services is increasing.	• A. Yes • B. No • C. Not Given